Resources

- Introduction to the Painted Essay® Slides
- The Painted Essay® Template
- Painting or coloring materials in red, yellow, blue, and green

Target Outcomes

Student Learning Outcomes

ELA

- Engage effectively in teacher-led and one-on-one discussions with various partners.
- Acquire grade-appropriate domain-specific words and phrases.
- Take notes on sources and categorize information.

Language Development

- Orally explain the purpose and structure of the Painted Essay using **because** to justify thinking.

Introduction to the Painted Essay®

Set Purpose

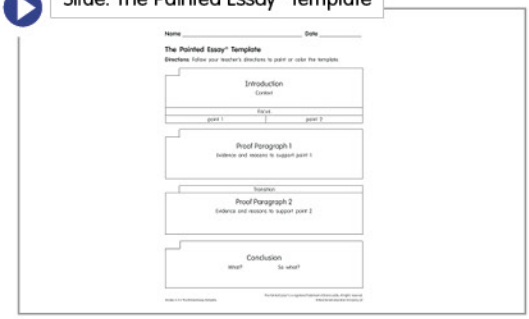
Today, we will learn about the structure of a basic essay, using a tool called the Painted Essay. This tool will show you how to organize your writing and help you better understand the characteristics of effective informative/explanatory and opinion pieces. We will use this tool throughout the year.

- Display and read aloud the Student Learning Outcome.

Introduce the Painted Essay (20 MIN.)

- Explain that an essay is a piece of writing that gives information or expresses the writer's opinion on a particular topic. Today, students will use color to help them remember the parts of an essay and understand how these parts work together to clearly explain the writer's thinking.
- Have students access The Painted Essay® Template and their painting or coloring supplies.
- Display The Painted Essay® Template.

Slide: The Painted Essay® Template



- Tell students that each of the white rectangles represents a paragraph in the essay.

How many paragraphs are there in this essay? (four)

- Explain that each of the four paragraphs has a name and a special job or function.

We use color to help us remember the name of each paragraph and its purpose in the essay.

© 2028 Benchmark Education Company LLC

Paint or Color the Introduction

Context

Put your finger on the first paragraph on the page. This is the introduction.

- Explain that one of the jobs of the introduction is to give background information, or context, so that the reader can understand the essay.
- Tell students that the introduction should also catch the reader's attention, so they want to keep reading.

Red is a color that grabs our attention, so we will lightly shade the context part of the introduction red.

- Model painting or coloring the top part of the template of the introduction, stopping at the line above the word **focus**. Remind students to be careful not to paint or color the focus statement yet.
- Direct students to paint or color this paragraph red.

Put your brush (or colored pencil) down when you are done.

- Give students a few minutes to color the introduction.

Please put your brushes (or pencils) down. If you have not finished coloring or painting, you will get time to finish at the end of the lesson.

Focus Statement

- Direct students to the focus statement at the end of the introduction.

The focus statement is the most important part of your essay. It drives your piece, like the steering wheel of a car. The focus statement tells the reader what your piece will be about.

A focus statement has three parts that work together. The first part is the focus, which tells the central idea of the piece.

- Instruct students to lightly paint or color the focus part of the template green. Students should still be able to read the word **focus** underneath the color.

Put your brush (or colored pencil) down when you are done.

- Explain that in addition to the focus that tells the central idea, the focus statement has two points that are used to support it: point 1 and point 2.
- Model painting or coloring "point 1" yellow and "point 2" blue. Instruct students to paint or color "point 1" yellow and "point 2" blue.

What color do yellow and blue make? (Sample response: green)

- Explain that point 1 and point 2 work together to help the reader understand the central idea of the piece.

The focus statement is composed of three parts: the focus, point 1, and point 2. Paint (or draw) a line boxing these three parts together.

PROFESSIONAL LEARNING

The Science Behind the Practice

The Painted Essay

The Painted Essay is introduced to students as a concrete perceptual motor experience (painting or coloring a graphic representation of an essay) that helps the learner understand and visualize the components of an effective expository essay.

Grounding instruction in perceptual motor experiences has been shown to support "comprehension, learning, and later use of the information."

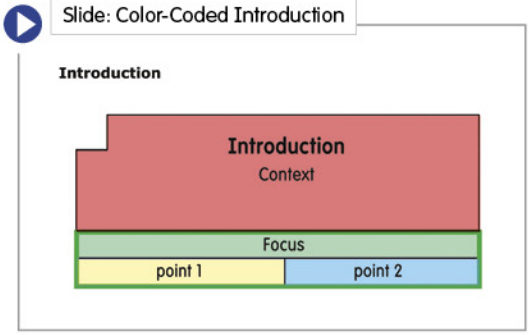
—Glenberg & Kaschak

© 2028 Benchmark Education Company LLC

- Model painting or coloring a line around the three elements of the focus statement: the focus, point 1, and point 2. Instruct students to do the same.

Put your brush (or colored pencil) down when you are done.

Slide: Color-Coded Introduction



Paint or Color Proof Paragraph 1

Put your finger on the second paragraph in your essay. This next paragraph is called proof paragraph 1.

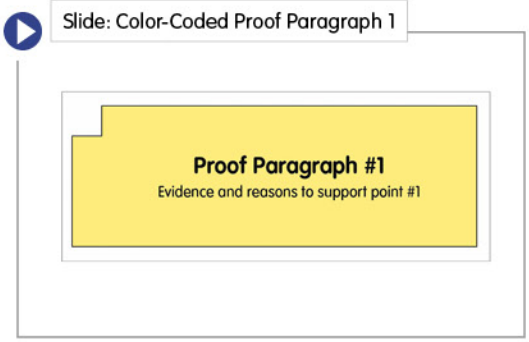
- Explain that the job of proof paragraph 1 is to give evidence and reasons to support the first point of the focus statement.

What color do you think we should paint proof paragraph 1, and why?
(yellow, because it goes with point 1 of the focus statement)

- Model painting or coloring the rectangle for "proof paragraph 1" yellow.
- Instruct students to lightly paint or color "proof paragraph 1" yellow.

Put your brush (or colored pencil) down when you are done.

Slide: Color-Coded Proof Paragraph 1



Paint or Color Proof Paragraph 2

Put your finger on the third paragraph in your essay. This is proof paragraph 2.

- Explain that at the beginning of proof paragraph 2, there is a special sentence called a transition. Tell students that they will come back to the transition. First, they will learn about proof paragraph 2.
- Explain that the job of proof paragraph 2 is to give evidence and reasons to support the second point of the focus statement.

PROFESSIONAL LEARNING

Teacher-Tested Practices

Colors in the Painted Essay

It is important that students listen attentively to the explanation why each color was chosen. Wait until all brushes or pencils are down before moving on to the next step.

Students will vary in how long it takes them to color each block. Keep the pacing lively. As long as students begin to color each block when directed, they will have no trouble completing their graphic independently later on.

—Diana Leddy, The Vermont Writing Collaborative

© 2028 Benchmark Education Company LLC

What color should we paint proof paragraph 2, and why? (blue, because it goes with point 2 of the focus statement)

- Model painting or coloring the rectangle for proof paragraph 2 blue.
- Instruct students to skip the transition and lightly paint or color the proof paragraph 2 part of the template with blue, as they did with point 2 of their focus.

Put your brush (or colored pencil) down when you are done.

Transition

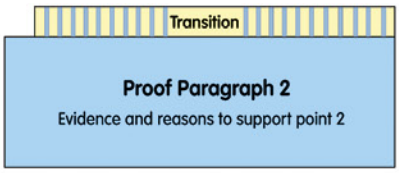
- Direct students back to the transition part of the template.

This line is called a transition. A transition is a sentence that moves the reader from one big point in your piece to the next.

- Elaborate that the transition is a sentence that has the job of bridging the ideas in the yellow proof paragraph 1 and the blue proof paragraph 2, so it should be painted yellow and blue.
- Model painting or coloring the transition yellow and blue. Explain that students should try not to mix the colors, but rather they should include both colors in the transition line.
- Instruct students to color the transition yellow and blue.

iELD **Total Physical Response:** Engage students in TPR to support their understanding of the word **transition**.

Slide: Color-Coded Proof Paragraph 2



Paint or Color the Conclusion

Put your finger on the last paragraph in your essay. This is the conclusion.

- Explain that the name of the last paragraph is the conclusion. Its job is to wrap up the piece and it has two parts: a "What?" and a "So What?"

In your conclusion, you want to remind the reader of your focus, the "What?" but also add in your own thinking about why what you said is important, the "So What?"

- Explain that in their conclusion, students will remind the reader of the ideas in proof paragraph 1 and proof paragraph 2, and add their own thinking about the topic. Instruct students to mix yellow and blue to combine these ideas and see what they get.

PROFESSIONAL LEARNING

Teacher-Tested Practices

Order of Colors in the Painted Essay

It is important for students to color Proof Paragraph 2 blue before coloring the transition. Only after they have colored the yellow and blue paragraphs will students understand why the transition, which connects those paragraphs, is yellow and blue. The colors of the Painted Essay do more than prompt students to remember the parts of an essay. Rather, the patterns and relationship between the colors support students in understanding the complex relationship between those parts.

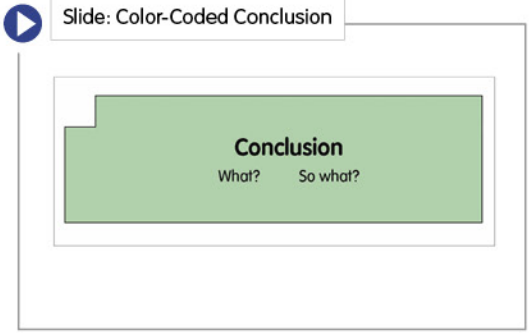
—Diana Leddy, The Vermont Writing Collaborative

© 2028 Benchmark Education Company LLC

- Tell students to look around the classroom and observe the many different shades of green their classmates have made for their conclusions. Explain that this demonstrates that even if everyone is working with similar information from the texts, each person will have their own ideas and insights about that information. The conclusion is a unique shade of green, just like their own unique thinking.
- Model painting or coloring the conclusion rectangle green.
- Instruct students to lightly paint or color the conclusion part of the template with their own unique shade of green.

Put your brush (or colored pencil) down when you are done.

Slide: Color-Coded Conclusion



Debrief the Painted Essay (9 MIN.)

Let's review what you learned today about the Painted Essay.

- Use questions like the following to review the parts of the Painted Essay. Have students share answers with their partners before you confirm the correct answers with the whole class.

Show your partner the paragraph that has the job of wrapping up the essay. (conclusion—green part) *Why is this colored green?* (because its job is to remind the reader of the focus and add your own unique thinking)

Show your partner the part that has the job of giving the reader background information, or context, so the reader can understand the piece. What color is it and why? (introduction—red part, catches the reader's attention)

Show your partner the part of the essay that tells the reader what the piece will be about. It includes the central idea of your piece and two points. (focus statement) *What colors are found in the focus statement?* (green, yellow, and blue)

Show your partner the part that has the job of being a bridge between your two points. (transition) *What colors are in the transition?* (yellow and blue) *Why is the transition yellow and blue?* (It moves the reader from the ideas in your yellow paragraph to the ideas in your blue paragraph.)

Show your partner the part that has the job of giving evidence and reasons to support the first point in your focus statement. (proof paragraph 1) *What color is this paragraph? Why?* (yellow, to match the yellow point in the focus statement)

PROFESSIONAL LEARNING

Teacher-Tested Practices

Access: Think Aloud to Model the Painted Essay

Referring to the Painted Essay graphic helps students understand the structure and purpose of each part of their writing, guiding them to focus on the specific job of each section. This visual and verbal scaffolding supports coherence and clarity in their writing process.

—The Vermont Writing Collaborative, 2017

Teacher-Tested Practices

Use Repetition to Internalize Structure

Students will need lots of experience to help them internalize the language and structure of The Painted Essay. Activities like those in the Debrief are a great way to utilize an unexpectedly free 10 minutes, even later in the year. Most students enjoy them, and each repetition brings them closer to internalizing the structure.

—Diana Leddy, The Vermont Writing Collaborative

© 2028 Benchmark Education Company LLC

Show your partner the part that has the job of giving evidence and reasons to support the second point in your focus statement. (proof paragraph 2) *Why is it blue?* (to match the blue point in the focus statement)

- Confirm that students understand that the Painted Essay has four paragraphs: introduction, proof paragraph 1, proof paragraph 2, and conclusion. These parts together form a complete essay. The colors can help students remember each paragraph and understand how the paragraphs work together to make meaning.

ACCESS Conduct a Think-Aloud to support students as they identify different parts of the Painted Essay.

iELD **Leverage Linguistic Assets:** Encourage students to use their home languages, if helpful, as they review the concepts of the Painted Essay. For example: *Would you like to use your home language as you review the parts of the essay and discuss the meaning of the colors with your partner?*

EXTEND Ask Guiding Questions to challenge students in orally sharing the purpose of the Painted Essay.

Wrap Up (1 MIN.)

- Have students use the Turn and Talk Protocol to share one thing they learned or found interesting about the Painted Essay.
- Congratulate students on their work today.

Formative Assessment: Look Fors

ASSESS ✓ Prior to the next writing lesson, review students' The Painted Essay® Templates. Did students:

✓ Correctly paint or color the different parts of the essay?

✓ Correctly identify each part and its purpose in the essay?

As needed, provide additional support during future writing lessons.

Have students save their templates of the Painted Essay to refer to throughout the school year. If possible, laminate the templates or put them in a sheet protector.

PROFESSIONAL LEARNING

Teacher-Tested Practices

Teaching the Painted Essay in Order

Notice that in this lesson, students are not connecting the colors to sample paragraphs or sentences. This is intentional. Students need some time to explore the visual representation before attaching linguistic information to it. In the next writing lesson, students will color-code a model essay and begin to make those connections. Real understanding will build in layers, as students work with the structure throughout the year.

—Diana Leddy, The Vermont Writing Collaborative

© 2028 Benchmark Education Company LLC